SULCATA TORTOISE

Centrochelys sulcata

1. What can it see, hear, or feel?
Its nose finds dry grass, its eyes spot movement, and it feels vibrations through the ground.

2. Where does it live — and why?
It lives in Africa's dry grasslands, digging deep burrows to escape the midday heat.

3. How does it send messages?
Males make a loud mating call, ram each other with their shells, and move to water after rain.

4. What does it do when something changes?
In peak heat it hides in its burrow; in very dry times it moves less to save energy.

5. How does it learn?
Young tortoises hatch alone and learn by trying which plants to eat in their new home.

6. How does it have babies?
A mother digs a nest and lays up to thirty eggs, which hatch about ninety days later.

7. What are its limits?
Cold is dangerous for it, and without burrows or shade, it can quickly overheat and die.

8. What does this teach us?
Slow body, dry diet, and deep burrows all work together as one survival system.

WHY IS THIS ANIMAL HERE?

Sulcata tortoises live in the dry grasslands south of the Sahara Desert.

Their grasslands are drying out and being converted to farmland.

They are also collected heavily for the pet trade worldwide.

When its habitat shrinks:

- food and water become harder to find in a drying climate
- pet tortoises grow huge and often outlive their owners
- released pets rarely survive and cannot always go back

This place is not their natural home, but it can help keep the species alive.

THINK ABOUT THIS

If you carried your home on your back, what would you want that home to be made of?

What a living thing can sense becomes its reality.
Environment shapes design.

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